

opportunities for the entire world,” the tournament will also serve as a dress rehearsal for the expanded 48-team FIFA World Cup to be held in the USA, Canada and Mexico in the summer of 2026.

What’s changed in the format?

The Club World Cup debuted in 2000 in Brazil with eight teams, where Corinthians defeated Vasco da Gama on penalties to claim the title. Financial and logistical issues led to a three-year hiatus, but the competition returned in 2005 and ran annually until 2023 with seven teams: the six continental champions and the host nation’s league winner.

UEFA and CONMEBOL representatives received byes to the semifinals, and the event typically lasted under two weeks.

From now on, the tournament will take place every four years and feature 32 clubs.

The format will mirror that of the FIFA World Cup — eight groups of four, followed by single-leg knockout rounds from the round of 16 to the final. There will be no third-place play-off.

How did teams qualify?

Team selection was based on performances between 2021 and 2024.

Each year’s continental champions were awarded direct qualification. Additional spots were granted to the best-performing clubs from each confederation over the four-year period, using a ranking pathway. UEFA received the highest allocation with 12 slots.

Major League Soccer club Inter Miami was granted entry as the host nation’s representative. Another MLS side, Los Angeles FC, qualified by defeating Club América in a play-off, after Club Leon was disqualified in March for breaching ownership rules.

What is the special transfer window?

Given the timing of the tournament at the end of the club season, FIFA has introduced a special transfer window from June 1 to 10 for the 32 teams.

Clubs can register new signings during this window, making them eligible to feature in the tournament.

FIFA has also created an in-competition transfer window from June 27 to July 3. This allows clubs to adjust their squads mid-tournament.

According to FIFA, “The objective is to encourage clubs and players whose contracts are expiring to find an appropriate solution to facilitate the players’ participation. This will ensure that the best players are playing, allowing clubs to add new recruits even during the tournament.”

What’s the prize?

While concerns around the scheduling and player workload persist, FIFA has set an enticing financial incentive: a prize pool of 1 billion USD will be shared among the 32 teams, with the winner set to take home up to 125 million USD.

The Club World Cup returns in a radically new form, and all eyes will be on whether it evolves into a celebrated tradition or ends up as yet another burden on clubs already stretched to the limit.



CONFEDERATION-WISE BREAKDOWN OF TEAMS

Africa (CAF) – 4 teams

3 via Champions Pathway (CAF Champions League); 1 via Ranking Pathway

Asia (AFC) – 4 teams

3 via Champions Pathway (AFC Champions League); 1 via Ranking Pathway

Europe (UEFA) – 12 teams

4 via Champions Pathway (UEFA Champions League); 8 via Ranking Pathway

North, Central America & Caribbean (CONCACAF) – 4 teams

3 via Champions Pathway (CONCACAF Champions Cup); 1 via Play-In Match

Oceania (OFC) – 1 team

Via Ranking Pathway

South America (CONMEBOL) – 6 teams

4 via Champions Pathway (CONMEBOL Libertadores); 2 via Ranking Pathway

Host Country – 1 team

STADIUMS

Mercedes-Benz Stadium – Atlanta, GA
TQL Stadium – Cincinnati, OH
Bank of America Stadium – Charlotte, NC
Rose Bowl Stadium – Los Angeles, CA
Hard Rock Stadium – Miami, FL
GEODIS Park – Nashville, TN
MetLife Stadium – New York/New Jersey
Camping World Stadium – Orlando, FL
Inter Miami Stadium – Orlando, FL
Lincoln Financial Field – Philadelphia, PA
Lumen Field – Seattle, WA
Audi Field – Washington, D.C.

GROUPS

A: SE Palmeiras (BRA), FC Porto (POR), Al Ahly FC (EGY), Inter Miami CF (USA)

B: Paris Saint-Germain (FRA), Atlético de Madrid (ESP), Botafogo (BRA), Seattle Sounders FC (USA)

C: FC Bayern München (GER), Auckland City FC (NZL), CA Boca Juniors (ARG), SL Benfica (POR)

D: CR Flamengo (BRA), Espérance Sportive de Tunis (TUN), Chelsea FC (ENG), Los Angeles FC (USA)

E: CA River Plate (ARG), Urawa Red Diamonds (JPN), CF Monterrey (MEX), FC Internazionale Milano (ITA)

F: Fluminense FC (BRA), Borussia Dortmund (GER), Ulsan HD (KOR), Mamelodi Sundowns FC (RSA)

G: Manchester City (ENG), Wydad AC (MAR), Al Ain FC (UAE), Juventus FC (ITA)

H: Real Madrid C.F. (ESP), Al Hilal (KSA), CF Pachuca (MEX), FC Salzburg (AUT)